

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 260

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Section Title(S): DEVIATION FROM THE RULES

On the whole, the !Kung conform strictly to the regulations among consanguineous kin and primary affines. None of the persons whose genealogical records we gathered (about 175) had married lineal kin or collaterals through first cousins. However, informants told about two !Kung men in Botswana who had married their cousins: the discussion suggested that the cousins were first cousins, but I do not know whether they were cross or parallel cousins. What was interesting was the attitude of the informants. They said that the men should not have done this, but there was no talk of madness or danger or expressions of horror, such as we had observed when incest was spoken of at other times. No punishments, social or divine, had been meted out, according to the informants. Some said they thought it was not too bad a thing for a man to do, especially if the woman were a FaSiDa, who is not, they said, so much like your sister as a MoSiDa is. I believe that the system's allowing joking with cousins, although it prohibits marriage with them, may mitigate the force of the incest taboo and accounts to some extent for the tolerance toward the breakers of this rule.

684
[Sex And Marital
 Offenses](#)

How much deviation there is in marrying second and third cousins I do not know. I soon gave up trying to gather data on kin more remote than first cousins, because informants so often did not know the names and I could not rely on the information. I imagine there is considerable deviation in these categories.

684
[Sex And Marital
 Offenses](#)

One account came to our ears of a man who had violated the incest taboo with his stepdaughter. He was /Gunda Legs, and he lived with Band 9. He is dead now. What he did was so outside the good and the normal that it could be accounted for only by madness. He had drunk the milk of a young

571
[Social Relationships
 And Groups](#)

gemsbok doe, the people told us, and this is what had made him mad. Something came from his forehead and went in and out, a sort of swelling. After that he fell in love with his stepdaughter, N^oisa, and married her, and both she and her mother were his wives at the same time. The people "laughed at him" so much because he had made such a horrifying "mistake" that he took his stepdaughter and lived apart from his band—the only instance we know of a man and woman living alone. They had a son, ^oToma, who died young. When /Gunda's madness waned, he sometimes came back to his people; he would go again when his madness returned. People said they did not understand why N^oisa went with him. They mocked her, saying that she was *dole* ("bad") and 261 that it was "nonsense" to fall in love with one's stepfather. Our informants laughed uneasily when they told about these people, as they laugh when they tell of vultures eating their meat, or of being chased by fierce bees when they try to take a honeycomb. There came to my mind a penetrating remark made by //Kushay, the wife of /Qui, which might, I thought, be applied to N^oisa. //Kushay had said, "When a *jũ wã* girl goes against the customs of her people and people talk about her and say she is bad, she is very unhappy. She would hear the people talking and be ashamed and would come to them angry." Or, I thought, go away because she was ashamed.

626
Social Control

684
Sex And Marital
Offenses

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